

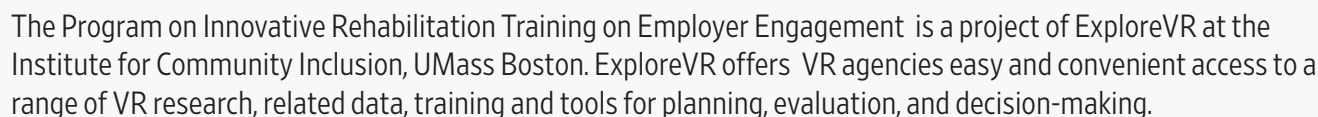


INNOVATIVE GUIDED REHABILITATION EMPLOYER ENGAGEMENT TRAINING

Employer Engagement: An iGREET Trainer Companion Guide



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A companion guide for agency staff trainers to use in facilitating professional development opportunities on employer engagement, in conjunction with the iGREET online course.



IGREET STAFF TRAINING GUIDE

The Program on Innovative Rehabilitation Training on Employer Engagement (PIRTEE) at the Institute for Community Inclusion (ICI), University of Massachusetts Boston, is pleased to share our comprehensive curriculum for the Innovative Guided Rehabilitation Employer Engagement Training (iGREET).

This curriculum is designed to assist vocational rehabilitation (VR) professionals, paraprofessionals, and students in improving employer engagement capacities and services to businesses to enhance opportunities for people with disabilities. VR programs have traditionally focused on job seekers with disabilities as their primary customers; however, the current national goal of VR is to provide a *dual-customer approach* by serving both job seekers and employers. To support this dual-customer approach, the iGREET online modules offer comprehensive learning objectives, evidence-based and promising practices, resource materials, and other information relevant to working with businesses as employers of individuals with disabilities.

The language used in the iGREET curriculum targets a VR audience, but the underlying principles and information will be useful to anyone who is engaging with the business community on behalf of job seekers and employees with disabilities (e.g., community rehabilitation providers, school transition specialists, workforce partners, and others).

Using the iGREET Online Modules for Staff Training

Agencies may wish to use a group-learning model, with trainees working through the iGREET online modules as part of a cohort and participating in supplemental discussions and other exercises led by an in-house trainer.

While the iGREET online content is engaging, without a facilitated group learning model, it may not give trainees opportunities to a) fully understand how employer engagement is implemented in their specific agency, b) practice their skills, or c) discuss additional employer engagement situations and strategies. This is where an agency-sponsored cohort of trainees could be beneficial. An in-house trainer can introduce and facilitate group discussions, case studies, role plays, and more to help engage the cohort.

Carefully consider the most appropriate trainer for the material. While in-house training staff may have strong facilitation skills, trainees could also benefit from a partnership with internal subject matter experts who have employer engagement experience.

The goals of the iGREET Train the Trainer guide are to ensure that every person involved in the training:

1. feels as though they know what to say and how to say it, and
2. practices what they learn before engaging the employer audience.



Using the Staff Trainer Companion Guide

This guide will support trainers in facilitating cooperative learning opportunities for training cohorts. **In this guide, you will find:**

1. **Explanations of the objectives** and desired outcomes/takeaways of each module and specific lessons within each module.
2. **Case studies and scenarios** presented in the online lessons and additional case study/scenario examples, which are listed at the end of each lesson for review and further discussion. You can find these documents and any other additional Quick Guides and related resources on the [iGREET resource page](#).
3. **Resources and background information** (Quick Guides) providing additional information about many topics covered in the modules.
4. **Strategies** for completing and discussing fieldwork activities.
5. **Discussion topics and exercises** to expand learning opportunities for trainees, including team projects, agency strategy development, and more.
6. **Videos** on the [iGREET video channel](#). These are the videos that we use in the online training. They are organized by module in the video channel, identified as resources at the end of each lesson in this trainer guide, and are available for review and discussion at the trainer's discretion.

Note: *As we make updates to the iGREET curriculum, these online resources may change slightly.*

A note about relevancy: These resources were developed for use by state VR agencies, and this companion guide largely reflects that focus. However, in most lessons, we provide additional discussion topics and exercises to assist non-VR trainers and trainees in applying the information and resources.

Considerations for Trainers

Please keep the following important notes in mind as you provide employer engagement instruction using the iGREET online course:

- » **Provide discussion and application exercises after each lesson, whenever possible.** This will allow trainees to fully digest and expand upon the content covered in each lesson. Waiting until the end of the module or entire course delays the application of content and key principles, which are better reinforced after each lesson.
- » **Be prepared to discuss agency policies and practices.** During the process of leading a cohort of trainees through the iGREET lessons and modules, questions or concerns about agency policies and practices may come up that are beyond the scope of the iGREET training or beyond the staff trainer's role to address. (Of course, this may also occur during training on other topics.) In addition, some of the suggested iGREET exercises invite consideration of agency employment engagement efforts and how they might be improved.
- » **Develop a “parking lot” approach in your training.** The trainer should address questions and concerns about employer engagement in the moment, or record and forward them to the employer engagement lead/manager/team. If issues come up that are separate from or broader than employer engagement, such as concerns about the quality of community



rehabilitation provider services, the trainer can acknowledge and record these questions/concerns on a “parking Lot” list. This way, iGREET lesson application activities can continue. The separate questions/concerned can be “parked” in the lot to address later.

- » **Use the iGREET webpage for additional information.** In addition to the Train-the-Trainer Companion Guide, the iGREET team created a guide for supervisors and leadership of VR agencies. For information, please visit the [iGREET webpage](#) on [explorevr.org](#). This information can be a valuable resource for your agency.
- » **Understand the needs, experience, and responsibilities of your audience.** Activities, discussions, and priorities identified for your training may differ, depending on who is participating. For example, community rehabilitation provider (CRP) staff may have different interactions with employers and different responsibilities for employer engagement than a business services specialist that works for a state VR agency.
- » Employer engagement is a skill that must be developed, so get your group practicing with one another as much as possible! There is always the opportunity to **evaluate where your trainees are content-wise**. Consider introducing other trainers or experts to discuss specific topics or find ways to engage the trainees if the materials presented don’t resonate with your group.
- » Consider how you can establish or contribute to an **ongoing professional development approach** around employer engagement in your agency. This training can be a starting point, not a last step.

Accessing the iGREET Online Modules

The iGREET course consists of four modules and fifteen lessons, each building upon the last, in terms of skills and complexity in employer engagement strategies. You can take each module individually but most participants, including experienced staff, have found value in completing all four modules sequentially.

The iGREET course introduction includes directions and tips for navigating the online modules. Staff trainers should become familiar with access to pre-tests, discussions, and resources to assist participants as needed.

You can access the iGREET online modules by registering staff individually during an open cohort. See the [iGREET webpage](#) for additional information on cohort dates, registration, and completion requirements. Participants may earn certified rehabilitation counselor (CRC) credit upon completion of each module. After completing the entire course, participants will receive a certificate of completion.

For more information about the UMass Boston Institute for Community Inclusion (ICI) and training provided through iGREET, please visit [explorevr.org](#) or contact igreetonlinelearning@umb.edu.

Suggested Evaluation Questions

Once you have completed the in-house training sessions on iGREET content, ask participants to provide some evaluative feedback to help improve your approach for the next time. Here are some **possible** questions:

- » What was your biggest takeaway from the iGREET training?
- » Did you feel like some topic areas were missing? Were there areas we could have spent more time on?
- » What pieces of training will you apply to your day-to-day work?
- » Would you recommend all newly hired staff take this course? Why or why not?



MODULE 1: FOUNDATIONS OF EMPLOYER ENGAGEMENT

Module 1 lays the foundation for employer engagement in vocational rehabilitation (VR) agencies. Module 1 explains how employer engagement supports the goal of developing employment opportunities for people with disabilities.

The learning objectives for Module 1 include:

1. Explain the evolution of VR employer services through the context of legislative history.
2. Describe the benefits of the dual-customer approach to job seekers and to employers.
3. Recognize how collaboration with WIOA and other community partners leads to meeting the needs of the dual customers.
4. Identify the power of effective communication, including the use of business-friendly language, and model disability-inclusive and culturally respectful language.
5. Review strategies for ensuring ethical employer engagement.
6. Recognize opportunities to research and use labor market information to direct employer engagement connections.
7. Determine the steps for initiating engagement with employers.

Module 1 consists of four lessons, each of which will be explained in further detail, including opportunities for facilitated discussion and activities:

Lesson 1: Understanding the Expectations of WIOA & the Dual-Customer Approach

Lesson 2: Ethical Considerations in Employer Engagement

Lesson 3: Language and Communication for Effective Employer Engagement

Lesson 4: Preparing for, Coordinating, & Initiating Employer Engagement Activities

Module 1, Lesson 1: Understanding the Expectations of WIOA and the Dual-Customer Approach

Lesson summary for trainers:

For some, serving both employers and people with disabilities as VR customers may seem unfamiliar and/or like a waste of resources and staff time. VR's fundamental purpose is to support the training and employment goals of people with disabilities. This lesson lays the foundation of why serving employers as well as job seekers advances VR's ability to support employment goals for people with disabilities. This lesson also explains how that evolution took place within VR and the larger workforce development system. Without this foundational knowledge, staff may have misunderstandings and doubts about the legitimacy of the iGREET course.

Background knowledge and expertise:

Trainers should have knowledge of:

- » the laws and legislation (past and present) that fund and provide guidance for VR services to employers
- » evolution of legislation leading VR toward providing employer engagement



- » your agency's values and plan for employer engagement
- » the agency's strategy for training staff on employer engagement and strategies for supporting staff who are reluctant to serve employers

This lesson may initiate a conversation about why VR is providing employer engagement services that may be perceived as taking services away from job-seeking clients. Helping staff understand the advantages of working with the employer community is an invaluable component of supporting job seeker goals.

Suggested discussion questions and activities:

1. How has your agency been engaging and serving employers in the last year? What has gone well and what do you think is missing?
2. How do you see the benefits of having a business customer focus to help support the agency's goals of helping people with disabilities to be successful in employment while meeting the needs of business?
3. Have you heard from co-workers who are concerned about serving employers as a customer? Or have you felt this concern yourself? How can you explain the need for VR to serve employers and job seekers with disabilities?
4. Whatever your role, how do you see employer engagement/services aligning with your work in serving general and/or pre-employment transition services (Pre-ETS) customers?
5. Is considering the business as a customer of your agency new to you? How do you (or how can you) approach your support of job-seeking customers as a service to businesses?

Resources for Module 1, Lesson 1:

- » iGREET MIL1: Harriet & Help Wanted (Case Scenario)
Scenario for discussion: a new employer and strategies for developing an employer engagement connection.
- » iGREET MIL1: Reluctant Colleague (Case Scenario)
Scenario for discussion: ways to discuss how employer engagement benefits the VR agency and its job-seeking clients with co-workers who are reluctant to embrace or accept the dual-customer approach.
- » iGREET MIL1: WIOA and Dual-Customer (Quick Guide)
This iGREET Quick Guide explains the WIOA regulations that reference services to employers and performance indicators used by the WIOA core partners.

Videos for Module 1, Lesson 1

- » The Evolution of Employer Engagement

Module 1, Lesson 2: Ethical Considerations for Employer Engagement

Lesson summary for trainers:

Ethical standards and behaviors are clearly outlined when providing VR counseling services. Talking about these issues in the context of employer engagement, however, is not as common. This lesson discusses the standards of ethical attitudes and behaviors that we must uphold as employer engagement professionals. This lesson provides opportunities to explore examples of when these dilemmas might arise.



Background knowledge and expertise:

Trainers should be familiar with:

- » the most current [Code of Professional Ethics for Certified Rehabilitation Counselors](#). Be aware that the CRC code of ethics is updated periodically.
- » the 6 key principles of ethics, their definitions, and examples of how they apply to vocational counseling and employer engagement
- » the Ethical-Decision Making Model: trainers need to be comfortable helping staff develop sound problem-solving techniques consistent with the Ethical Decision-Making Model to address situations that occur and to establish a comfort level and strategy for staff to work together in addressing ethical dilemmas

Suggested discussion questions and activities:

1. Do you have an example of an interaction you have had with an employer that crossed the bounds of good ethical practice that you can share with the group to discuss?
 - Note: if no one shares, present a fictional scenario, and ask the staff to problem-solve together. Use the Ethical Decision-Making Model from the lesson as a structure for discussing these examples.
2. How do you monitor favoritism in the services you provide? Do you feel like certain employers get more preference than others in the community? Why is that, is it justified, and what are some ways that our agency can monitor and adjust for this?
3. What do you think about Peter's "One-Counselor, One-Caseload" monologue? Whatever your role, do you feel like you have a community at work to brainstorm or discuss challenging situations and decisions with? If not, how can you work to establish professional, intra-agency support?
4. Are there times that you have experienced ethical dilemmas based on differing expectations between you and a supervisor or your partner agency (e.g., VR/CRP)? What are some strategies you (can) use to address those situations?

Resources for Module 1, Lesson 2:

- » iGREET MIL2: Establishing Employer Engagement Boundaries (Case Scenario)
Scenario for discussion: ways to discuss how employer engagement benefits the VR agency and its job-seeking clients with co-workers who are reluctant to embrace or accept the dual-customer approach.
- » iGREET MIL2: APSE Ethical Guidelines
This [Association of People Supporting Employment First \(APSE\)](#) resource describes basic human principles for trainers of staff in supported employment to consider, including individuality, choice, respect, participation, competence, social inclusion, life support, career advancement, staff training, community settings with minimal intrusion, employment, career planning, job development, job acquisition, and work support.
- » iGREET MIL2: Commission on Rehabilitation Counselor Certification (CRCC) Professional Code of Ethics
This CRCC Code of Professional Ethics guides the ethical practice of rehabilitation counselors in (1) specifying ethical behavior expected, (2) establishing principles that guide ethical behavior, (3) serving as an ethical guide in constructing a professional course of action, and (4) serving as the basis for processing alleged Code violations.



- » iGREET M1L2: Ethical Decisions Model (Quick Guide)

This iGREET Quick Guide walks through a model of five steps in ethical decision-making.

- » iGREET M1L2: Principals of Ethics (Quick Guide)

This iGREET Quick Guide explains the six primary principles that guide professional ethics when making decisions in the work of Employer Engagement: 1) Autonomy, 2) Beneficence, 3) Non-maleficence, 4) Justice, 5) Fidelity, and 6) Veracity.

Module 1, Lesson 3:

Communication Skills for Effective Employer Engagement

Lesson summary for trainers:

This lesson discusses the power of language, which impacts many distinct aspects of employer engagement. In this lesson, we consider language from the following angles:

1. Using language as a tool for developing partnerships and professional connections
2. Ensuring that language is not creating barriers
3. Using business-friendly language rather than agency-speak
4. Using disability-respectful and culturally respectful language
5. Using language that is professional, and customized to the specific workplace culture

Background knowledge and expertise:

It is helpful if trainers:

- » are accustomed to interacting with business customers, can adequately explain what business-friendly language sounds like, and be able to give examples of how and why it is important
- » have a good understanding of cultural competence and how language reflects those values and insights, including disability-respectful language, as it is necessary for employer engagement representatives to model good language practices
- » are experienced with and can give examples of diverse types of business cultures and their language

Suggested discussion questions and activities:

1. In the interaction between Peter and Barbara, Peter had a lapse in using “VR speak” that Barbara briefly misunderstood. Have you ever had this happen to you?
 - When you think about your interactions with businesses, do you use “business-friendly” language, or is that something you need to practice?
2. One of the knowledge checks in this lesson is: *“True or False: The language that an employer engagement representative uses isn’t as important as the services they provide to the employer.” The answer is false, but why do you think this is the case?*
 - If someone disagrees with this answer, how would you help them understand the importance of language in engaging employers?
3. What are ways that you can help model culturally and disability-respectful language to others, including employers and co-workers?
 - How do you do this in a way that supports the goal without harming your relationship with the other party?



4. Ask staff to compare their notes about the video of Jonathan and the local tech startup.
 - What did the staff note about the industry terms that Jonathan used and in what ways they identified to best communicate with and learn about his company?
 - What are some industries in your area that staff will need to learn about and develop strategies to communicate with?
5. Once each of the staff has completed the suggested listening skills surveys, ask them to share their results and/or anything they learned from the results.
 - Ask each staff member to identify one area they can work on to continually improve listening skills (with the idea that we are all in a mindset of continual self-improvement, and not that they are deficient in something).
6. If you are providing employer engagement for customers of a funding agency (e.g., VR), how do you introduce yourself in business-friendly language that explains what you do but also references the funding agency that supports your work? If you are from a CRP, does VR provide materials or language for you to use in explaining their role?
7. Compare the language you would use with a bank manager vs. a welding shop. How do you gauge the most effective communication and prepare for the possible necessary communication techniques without making assumptions?

Resources for Module 1, Lesson 3:

- » iGREET M1L3: How Good are your Listening Skills? (from Mind Tools)
This test will help you consider how good your listening skills are and how to improve your listening skills moving forward.
- » iGREET M1L3: Listening-Skills-Self-Assessment
This self-evaluation tool will help you to be more aware of your listening habits, including those you can be happy about and those you might want to reshape.
- » iGREET M1L3: Business Terminology Examples (Quick Guide)
This iGREET Quick Guide explains a list of terms that will help get you started in your learning about the language of business, including language for hiring and industry-specific language.

Videos for Module 1, Lesson 3:

- » Russ and Neil: Business-Friendly Language
- » Peter and his lapse into “VR-speak”
- » Jonathan and the IT Start-up Company



Module 1, Lesson 4: Preparing for, Coordinating, and Initiating Employer Engagement Activities

Lesson summary for trainers:

The first three lessons helped lay a foundation for employer engagement and explored the foundational knowledge necessary to get started. This is the first lesson that specifically addresses how to initiate contact with and work with employers. It starts with ways to research employer priorities as well as labor market information (LMI). Using LMI and effective communication skills, students explore making a good first impression with targeted employers (including developing an effective “elevator pitch”) and presenting a professional image. The lesson also includes information about responding to employer objections.

Background knowledge and expertise:

Because this lesson is the first one in the iGREET series that directly involves the process of connecting with employers, it will be important to gauge the comfort level of staff in terms of talking with and supporting employers—are they completely new to this part of their job? Or do they have some experience, and may be more interested in developing new strategies and perfecting existing skills? Having a clear understanding of those perspectives will help you determine your training approach and what skills are necessary for you to emphasize in your training.

Some areas that are important to understand and have the tools, resources, and strategies to approach include:

- » how LMI is accessed and used in your agency and community: What websites, partner agencies, and internal connections can you provide to staff?
- » does your agency access and use the Talent Acquisition Portal (TAP)? If so, do staff know how to use it and feel comfortable communicating the options to job seekers and employers?
- » understanding best practices in speaking with employers (including elevator pitches) to provide constructive feedback to staff, which includes determining employer priorities

Suggested discussion questions and activities:

It is important that staff understand how to connect with all kinds of employers and not only the ones they are already familiar with. Trainers can take advantage of the fieldwork assignment and the elevator pitch video to support learning and foster discussion. Trainers will want to provide practice opportunities in employer interactions, feedback, and peer mentoring.

1. The Employer Mapping fieldwork exercise is an important activity for staff to complete, to “map out” the breadth and variety of employers that are in the community. Have staff complete this activity (individually or in groups) and discuss their results.
 - Were there industries, sectors, and employers they weren’t aware of?
 - Was there any additional information about the business community that they found surprising or interesting?
 - What can staff plan to do with that information to support their employer engagement work?
2. Have staff rewatch the elevator pitch video and talk about the information they can include in an elevator pitch.
 - Provide examples of diverse types of employers so they can develop their own elevator pitches and learn to customize their approach. This should include opportunities to practice and get feedback from peers.



3. Create examples of employers who are not receptive to an elevator pitch or who have objections to hiring people with disabilities (please see Employer Objections Handout). Have staff practice with each other in responding to those objections.
4. How can you use the LMI you seek for your customers (and through the Comprehensive Assessment process) for business engagement purposes?
5. Develop an elevator pitch to briefly educate an employer on VR services while completing a site visit for a customer (setting up a job shadow or work-based learning experience).
6. Develop an elevator pitch to introduce yourself to a new business owner in town that does not include an “ask” for a client placement.

Resources for Module 1, Lesson 4:

- » iGREET M1L4: Medical Supply Co. (Case Scenario)
Scenario for discussion: When introducing yourself to a Human Resources Manager at a medical supply company, discuss what you would do during that first introduction.
- » iGREET M1L4: Employer Mapping Exercise (Fieldwork Assignment)
This mapping exercise is one source of agency business engagement LMI. It can help you begin to look for a wider range of potential businesses and organizations to approach as part of your business engagement efforts.
- » iGREET M1L4: Employer Objections and Responses (Quick Guide)
This iGREET Quick Guide provides a list of employer objections, responses, and strategies to prepare you for when employers have concerns about hiring job seekers with disabilities.
- » iGREET M1L4: The Career Index (TCI Plus) Intro
This resource is an introduction to the Career Index Plus (TCI+): a career information system that collects LMI from a host of resources and deposits it onto a single, user-friendly site.

Web Resources:

- » US Bureau of Labor Statistics
- » Talent Acquisition Portal (TAP)

Videos for Module 1, Lesson 4:

- » First Impressions and Professionalism
- » The Elevator Pitch



MODULE 2: DEVELOPING AND MAXIMIZING PARTNERSHIPS FOR EMPLOYER ENGAGEMENT

Module 2 builds upon the foundations of Module 1 by looking at the internal and external partnership opportunities that you can use to maximize the agency's employer engagement potential.

The learning objectives for Module 2 include:

- » Identify available key partners for employer engagement.
- » Understand the elements and stages in the progression of partnership.
- » Demonstrate an understanding of laws and regulations that affect employment for people with disabilities.
- » Recognize multiple training and consultation opportunities and topic areas for employer services.
- » Seek out opportunities for messaging/marketing employer services.
- » Consider a variety of employer recognition and appreciation methods.

Module 2 consists of four lessons, each of which will be explained in further detail, including opportunities for facilitated discussion and activities:

Lesson 1: Tapping into Internal Expertise and Connections

Lesson 2: Building an Employer Engagement Portfolio

Lesson 3: Part 1: Identifying and Cultivating Network Connection; and Part 2: Partnering with Contracted Agencies

Lesson 4: Leveraging Partnerships

Module 2, Lesson 1: Tapping into Internal Expertise and Connections

Lesson summary for trainers:

The first lesson in Module 2 starts the discussion about partnerships by looking at the value of networking with internal colleagues to identify possible targets for employer engagement. Agency staff, regardless of their positions, have connections with the business community that can be leveraged to support employer engagement efforts. The lesson focuses on identifying internal VR partnerships that contribute to the dual-customer vision and goals of the agency, common models for employer engagement within VR agencies, internal communication strategies, and the value of accurate, up-to-date, and shared data about business customers.

Background knowledge and expertise:

The trainer should be well-grounded in the following:

- » the agency leadership's vision for employer engagement
- » the employer engagement model your agency uses and the key people involved
- » the type of employer and employer engagement data being collected, how it is being collected, and the methods for sharing that data (internally and with external partners)



Suggested discussion questions and activities:

1. It is important for all staff to know the employer engagement vision for their agency. If you are not secure in your self-knowledge and agency knowledge (i.e., what you represent, what you can offer, what your limits are), it is exceedingly difficult to bring your assets to the partnership table.
 - In one of the videos in this lesson, Peter says, “*we want to make sure we are presenting a consistent message aligned with the agency’s public image and brand identity.*” Do you feel that everyone understands your agency’s vision for employer engagement? What can be done to better communicate that vision and the agency’s employer engagement activities?
2. What employer engagement staffing model does your agency use (centralized, regional, or direct)?
 - Who is responsible for employer engagement?
 - Are there others who can support employer engagement activities?
3. How does your agency collect and share information about employer engagement activities?
 - Who is responsible for collecting and analyzing employer engagement data?
 - Is this the responsibility of specific staff members or is there an opportunity for all staff with employer contacts to enter data?
 - Option: rewatch the video titled *Everyone Serves a Role in Employer Engagement* from this lesson. Discuss ways that staff can develop or improve communication across the agency to share and learn business and community information and resources.
4. How does your agency bring together the supply side (VR counselors who have clients wanting work) and the demand side (employer engagement staff with knowledge of businesses with hiring needs)? What is the counselor’s role in bringing these sides together?
 - Have you experienced conflict within your agency between the supply and demand sides (if yes, the small group activity below may be beneficial)? It may be helpful to hold a staff discussion on how to alleviate conflict.
5. How is business intelligence shared in your agency (e.g., staff/unit meetings, job boards, email, huddles, shared database)?
6. You have a customer that you would like to refer to a job opening shared by the employer engagement specialist. The customer doesn’t meet the minimum qualifications requested by the employer, but the customer is really interested in this type of work. Would you make the referral, and if so, how would you go about that?
7. The business services specialist in your area has built a relationship with an employer in the area with good job opportunities and has several openings. Most of your customers in *job ready* status are working with a CRP for placement. What would you do with the information from the business specialist regarding these open positions that may be a fit for one or more of your customers?
8. Have you ever had an employer say to you “your clients wouldn’t be able to do this job?” How did you handle that situation? If not, how would you handle that if it happened?
9. How does your agency recognize employer engagement efforts and successes? Are employer engagement responsibilities built into job descriptions and performance evaluations?
- 10. Group activity for VR agencies:** consider the following scenarios (A–C) and answer these questions:
 - Can you pinpoint what may be the primary cause of the problem?
 - What steps can you take to remedy the situation?



Scenario A: An employer that you have been working with for two years calls you and states that he has been contacted by a CRP that finds jobs for people with disabilities. The CRP told the employer that the people they place are all clients of your agency. He is confused as to how to work with the CRP.

Scenario B: You work as an employer engagement specialist as part of your VR agency's centralized model of employer engagement. Your supervisor informs you that a local field office is referring job seekers to one of your employer accounts who does not meet hiring requirements. The employer is wondering how this can happen since he shared specific hiring requirements with you.

Scenario C: You are a field-based employer engagement specialist. Over the past year, you have visited and built relationships with several local businesses. The businesses are beginning to reach out to you seeking qualified candidates. So far, only two counselors of the 10 in your office have referred clients to these openings.

11. Small group activity for non-VR agencies: consider the following scenarios and answer the following questions:

- Can you pinpoint what may be the primary cause of the problem?
- What steps can you take to remedy the situation?

Scenario A: An employer that you have been working with for two years calls you and states that he has been contacted by an agency that said they find jobs for people with disabilities. The employer does not understand that the call he got was from a different CRP and wonders why he is receiving a call from different staff from your agency. He is frustrated with the “overlap” of communication and would like you to be the one who calls him, so he isn't “bombarded” with people to remember. How do you address his confusion? Do you attempt to collaborate with the other agency?

Scenario B: You are a field-based employment specialist. Over the past year, you have visited and built relationships with several local businesses. The businesses are beginning to reach out to you seeking qualified candidates. You communicate this effort to VR, but so far, only two counselors of the 10 in your region have referred clients to these openings. What steps can you take to provide candidates for this business? Are there other partners you would reach out to in your area to support this business's hiring needs?

Resources for Module 2, Lesson 1:

- » iGREET M2L1: Claudia and Internal LMI (Case Scenario)
 - Scenario for discussion: Consider how an employer engagement representative might approach making a connection with a new employer when a coworker mentions an office supply company opening a branch nearby.

Videos for Module 2, Lesson 1:

- » Everyone Serves a Role in Employer Engagement
- » Employer Story (Montana rural employer)
- » Data is Valuable When...



Module 2, Lesson 2: Building an Employer Engagement Portfolio

Lesson summary for trainers:

Having an employer engagement portfolio means that you have a catalog of resources, services, and areas of knowledge that you can share with employers. This includes consultative services and training you might consider making available to employers.

Having a “back pocket” knowledge of a subject area does not mean you are the expert on the topic. Rather, it demonstrates that you are familiar with the topic and that you know where to go or whom to go to for more details. This lesson provides an overview and Quick Guide handouts about federal and state laws, including the Rehabilitation Act, Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA), Family and Medical Leave Act (FMLA), Workers’ Compensation, Wage and Hour Laws, and the Work Opportunity Tax Credit. It also reviews areas of expertise for providing training to businesses and strategies for agency messaging, including websites, social media, brochures, and public service announcements.

Background knowledge and expertise:

Trainers should have:

- » a general knowledge of state and federal laws as they apply to employment for people with disabilities and where to find more information
- » an understanding of the agency’s policies regarding providing training to businesses
- » a familiarity with agency strategies for messaging (marketing) to employers
- » what consultative services and training services the agency can provide to employers, and how to access information that employers may need that you can share with employer engagement staff/class participants

Suggested discussion questions and activities:

1. What has been your experience with employers’ familiarity with laws related to employment for people with disabilities?
 - Have you encountered employers who have little or no knowledge of laws relating to employment for people with disabilities or have some misconceptions about the employment of people with disabilities?
 - You can find an example of an employment law quiz in the resource section, or you can create one that is state-specific to help staff with what they do or do not know (make it fun!).
2. The lesson suggests several topics for employer training—which do you think you could offer, and who within the agency has this expertise? Who else in your community could provide this training if an employer asks?
 - Disability Awareness and Etiquette
 - Understanding the ADA and Accommodations
 - Guidance on Section 503 Hiring for Federal Contractors/Subcontractors
 - Supporting Employees with a Range of Disabilities
 - Creating a Disability-Friendly Environment for Employees and Customers
 - Recruiting and Hiring Job Seekers with Disabilities
3. Are there any agency limits, guidelines, or restrictions on how or when training and other services can be provided to an employer?



4. Does the training that is offered by the local job center duplicate what your agency offers? Is there an opportunity for partnership?
5. What marketing and outreach materials are available to use with employers? Are they consistent with the agency's vision and goals for employer engagement?
6. What resources can you access if a question comes up involving laws or regulations that you don't feel comfortable addressing? For example, when an employer asks about who pays for accommodations, or about whether they can pay the job seeker less while he is in training.
7. Optional case study for group discussion: **Camilla and ACME**

You get a call from a former client, Camilla, who is seeking your advice and help. She has been successfully employed at ACME Storage & Rentals for three years. You helped her get the job through employer engagement activities.

ACME struck you as a good company to reach out to; they have six locations throughout the state and employ well over 75 people statewide. You established a limited, but good, relationship with Carlo, the company owner who agreed to hire Camilla as they had a need for an additional person to handle data management and assist in the office. After Camilla made it past the 90-day period and you were assured that all was going well, you ceased to have further interactions with him, at Camilla's request.

Camilla tells you that she really likes her job, coworkers, boss, and the company in general. She recently got a promotion, but she has some concerns about having to learn new computer applications; given her dyslexia, her learning curve on innovative technology can be a challenge. She is also concerned, as she has found out that she needs to have back surgery in two months. She needs to talk to her boss and the company about the required time off, which her doctor has said could be up to one month before she can return to the office. She only has two weeks of time off saved up and is worried about losing her job. She would like to meet with you to discuss her situation(s) and how to proceed. Camilla is also hoping you will re-engage with the employer as he may need some support in understanding accommodations, assistive technology, and understanding resources available to him as the employer.

Discussion Questions:

1. What are Camilla's and the employer's rights and responsibilities that impact this situation?
2. What can you provide for Camilla to support her through your agency's services—both with her job training needs and with her upcoming surgery? Are there other community agencies you can connect her with as well?
3. What employment laws and policies apply to this scenario? What kind of information can you provide to Camilla and to her employer?
4. You have not spoken with Carlos in three years at Camilla's request. What employer engagement strategies would you use to reconnect with him?
5. How do you feel about Camilla's request not to engage with this employer after her job looked like it was going to work out for her? How do you balance client requests such as this with your ongoing work with employers?

Resources for Module 2, Lesson 2:

- » iGREET M2L2: Camilla and ACME (Case Scenario)

Scenario for discussion: Camilla, a former client, asks you for advice and support in handling a training issue at work and how to address upcoming medical needs. Participants will use their knowledge of employment laws to help support Camilla and her employer.



» iGREET M2L2: Sample Quiz

This sample quiz includes some questions on the “back pocket” information that is covered in this lesson. This resource is provided as an example of what you can create for your staff to identify and practice what they know.

» iGREET M2L2: Camilla and First Meeting (Case Scenario)

Scenario for discussion: In the first meeting with an employer, the employer mentions the need for some staff training. This scenario will help you to consider what training and services your agency offers.

» iGREET M2L2: iGREET Back Pocket Employment Law Overview

This includes a general summary of employment-related laws and an area for you to add state-specific guidelines and laws that employers should be aware of.

» iGREET M2L2: Employers Practical Guide to Reasonable Accommodations

This resource summarizes the most frequent issues that employers have regarding accommodations and ADA compliance and describes the Job Accommodation Network's (JAN) practical ideas for resolving them.

» iGREET M2L2: ADA (Quick Guide)

This iGREET Quick Guide explains the Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA), a major civil rights legislation for people with disabilities.

» iGREET M2L2: Department of Labor (DOL) 14c of FLSA Fact Sheet

This fact sheet provides general information concerning the application of section 14(c) of the Fair Labor Standards Act (FLSA).

» iGREET M2L2: DOL Child Labor Law Fact Sheet

This fact sheet provides general information about the federal youth employment provisions applicable to nonagricultural occupations.

» iGREET M2L2: DOL FMLA Fact Sheet

The Family and Medical Leave Act (FMLA) provides job-protected leave from work for family and medical reasons. This fact sheet explains FMLA benefits and protections.

» iGREET M2L2 Workers' Comp (Quick Guide)

This iGREET Quick Guide explains Workers' Compensation, which is insurance funded through employer contributions that provide benefits to injured workers and liability insurance and protection for employers.

» iGREET M2L2: Wage and Hour (Quick Guide)

This iGREET Quick Guide explains Wage and Hour Laws, which are standards for minimum wage, overtime pay, record keeping, and youth employment.

» iGREET M2L2: WOTC (Quick Guide)

This iGREET Quick Guide explains Work Opportunity Tax Credits (WOTC), the federal tax credit that is available to employers if they hire people from specific targeted groups who are considered to have significant barriers to employment.

» iGREET M2L2: CIE (Quick Guide)

This iGREET Quick Guide explains the relevance and components of Competitive Integrated Employment (CIE).

» iGREET M2L2: Title V (Quick Guide)

This iGREET Quick Guide explains Title V, which covers insurance issues; explains the relationship between the ADA and other, previously existing laws; and defines explicit restrictions against retaliation or coercion against anyone with a disability who exerts their civil rights.



Module 2, Lesson 3 Part 1: Identifying and Cultivating External Partnerships

Lesson summary for trainers:

This lesson starts by reviewing the role of *trust* in developing relationships, illustrated by Zenger and Folkman's research on the three elements of trust and the importance of relationships. This leads to a review of key steps to developing relationships, and an introduction to the 5 Cs of *Partnership Development*: **1) Contact, 2) Connection, 3) Communication, 4) Coordination, and 5) Collaboration.**

This lesson also reviews a range of possible workforce system partnerships:

- » Workforce system partners, such as American Job Centers, community colleges, community rehabilitation providers or (CRPs), and industry/trade associations
- » business organizations, such as Chambers of Commerce, Society for Human Resource Management (SHRM), business round tables, and trade associations
- » advocacy organizations, such as State Rehabilitation Council, Governors' Committees on Employment for People with Disabilities, Developmental Disabilities Councils, provider organizations, and Disability:IN
- » a variety of business organizations

Because most of these partners have an employer engagement emphasis, we address strategies for avoiding duplication of services and confusion for the employer.

Part 1 wraps up with a discussion about addressing partnership difficulties and adapting existing partnerships as needed.

Background knowledge and expertise:

For this lesson, the trainer should know about:

- » the interagency partnerships in place for the agency and opportunities within the community and/or state to develop potential new partners, which includes other service providers, businesses, and education partners
- » a clear understanding of who at the agency bears responsibility for developing and maintaining these external partnerships (For example, the agency director may sit on the state Workforce Investment Board or participate in statewide business roundtables, while membership in local Chambers might be held by regional employer engagement specialists)
- » professional organizations and agencies, such as Disability:IN, SHRM, and economic development councils: it is helpful to know if these entities have local contacts or if they are nationally based

Suggested discussion questions and activities:

1. Ask training participants to complete a list of current and potential external partners in their community, region, and state. Then, use a group discussion to compare lists and add descriptions of what each partner does and how they can be useful in providing employer services. Note: this should be considered a "living" document, as agencies, roles, and priorities shift.
2. Use that list to evaluate which of the 5 C's best describes your status with that partner. The course's quick guides will be helpful in reviewing the 5 C's.



3. Review the scenario of Peter and the AJC (American Job Centers) working with the same employer—have you ever experienced anything like this? What are the potential challenges in this kind of partnership?
4. Do you feel like you understand your agency’s vision, policies, and procedures so you can make meaningful contributions toward partnership goals and avoid promising more than you can deliver? Where are the gaps?

Resources for Module 2, Lesson 3:

- » iGREET M2L3/P1: The 5 C’s (Quick Guide)
This iGREET Quick Guide explains the 5 Cs of partnership development (contact, connection, communication, coordination, and collaboration), to identify where you are in the process, what to watch for, and how to plan strategically for advancing relationships.
- » iGREET M2L3/P1: VR Partnerships Agency Descriptions
This resource describes VR partnerships with Workforce Investment Boards (WIBs), American Job Centers (AJCs), Community Colleges, community rehabilitation providers (CRPs), and Industry and Trade Associations.
- » iGREET M2L3/P1: Governors Guide Prompting Employment for People with Disabilities
This guide supports state and local governments in adopting and implementing inclusive policies and best practices that lead to increased employment opportunities for people with disabilities, and a stronger, more inclusive American workforce and economy.
- » iGREET M2L3/P1: Elements of Trust (Zenger and Folkman, HBR)
This research found three behaviors that form the foundation of trust: Positive Relationships, Good Judgment, and Consistency. Leaders don’t have to be perfect in all three to be successful—they simply need to be above average.

[Videos for Module 2, Lesson 3:](#)

- » Zenger and Folkman Research

Module 2, Lesson 3 Part 2: Partnering with Contracted Agencies

Lesson summary for trainers:

Part 2 reviews the diverse ways community rehabilitation providers (CRPs) can be involved in employer engagement and how good partnerships with the VR agency can be developed and maintained. It covers the advantages and challenges of these partnerships and illustrates typical VR and CRP roles and where they may overlap. Overall, the lesson emphasizes the need for clear dialogue between VR and CRPs, a collective understanding about expectations and quality standards, and a coordinated approach to employers.

Background knowledge and expertise:

The trainer should understand:

- » the role of CRPs in your agency’s employer engagement efforts and how those efforts are coordinated
- » how CRPs are contracted and paid for their efforts (e.g., hourly fee for services vs. outcome/milestone payments)
- » who is responsible for monitoring CRP services and outcomes
- » what is contractually required of CRPs in terms of their relationships with employers, and what is not contractually defined, but expected



Professional and interagency boundaries are often taken for granted and may become issues when communication and responsibilities are not clearly defined. It is important to understand management's view of and vision for employer engagement services for contracted agencies.

Suggested discussion questions and activities:

1. How well do you think the VR partnership with CRPs is working in your state? Where are the strengths and weaknesses?
2. What are your VR agency's expectations of the relationship between staff employer engagement efforts and the work being done by contractors (CRPs)? How are these efforts coordinated? Are there systems for sharing information in place?
3. How do your CRPs share information with employers about the VR agency's role? Do you expect them to distribute written information about VR?
4. How does your VR agency track employer engagement data? Do CRPs have access to the information, and/or contribute to the database? Is the information shared with other workforce partners?
5. As an employer engagement specialist, what is your role in ensuring that CRPs provide quality services to clients, employers, and the agency? How do you hold CRPs accountable for quality outcomes?
6. If you are a CRP, do you understand the quality outcomes expected by your state VR agency? Do they differ from those expected by other funding sources such as state Developmental Disabilities agencies?

Resources for Module 2, Lesson 3 Part 2:

- » iGREET M2L2/P2: Partnering with CRPs

Scenario for discussion: consider how an employer engagement representative should move forward when a CRP employer has concerns about the placement of visual cue cards around the worksite.

- » iGREET M2L2/P2: Business Engagement Partnerships: VR and CRPs

This fact sheet summarizes discussions and presentations from a forum held in December 2016. In addition, it reviews issues and strategies involved in the VR-CRP partnership for business engagement and employer support.

- » iGREET M2L2/P2: Article: Cross-System Partnerships

New Approaches to Customized Employment: Enhancing Cross-Systems Partnerships (Salon et al., 2018), Journal of Vocational Rehabilitation

- » iGREET M2L2/P2: Explore VR_CRPs White Paper

This document summarizes discussions and presentations from a forum held in December 2016, and reviews some issues and strategies involved in the VR-CRP partnership for business engagement and employer support.

- » iGREET M2L2/P2: Types of Contracts with VR

This resource outlines the characteristics, pros, and cons of CRP contracts for (1) outcome/milestone, (2) fee for service, and (3) assigned CRP staff types.

Videos for Module 2 Lesson 3 Part 2:

- » Developing Common Understanding



Module 2, Lesson 4: Leveraging Partnerships

Lesson summary for trainers:

This lesson continues the focus on employer engagement partnerships, including ways to alter or improve existing (or lapsed) partnerships. It includes information about The National Employment Team (The NET) and national partnerships, job fairs and work-based learning as partnership activities, and a discussion of business champions and employer recognition strategies.

Background knowledge and expertise:

For this lesson, it is helpful for trainers to have knowledge regarding:

- » your agency's participation in the NET, including who the agency's contact for the NET is
- » what types of job fairs the agency is already participating in and guidance for how to partner with other agencies in hosting community job fairs
- » opportunities for employer recognition, both on the state and local levels
- » understanding funding structures of work-based learning and how those opportunities may be coordinated with other agencies

Suggested discussion questions and activities:

1. What recognition or award efforts have been the most successful at your agency? What innovative approaches would you like to share?
2. This lesson presented a case scenario activity addressing the ethical responsibility of researching employers to make sure their business practices are legal and ethical before providing recognition for their work with job seekers/employees with disabilities

Possible follow-up questions:

- » What are some ways that our agency can double-check employers we might want to nominate for special recognition? What are our resources?
 - » How do we (or should we) document that information?
 - » What might be the consequences for providing public recognition to an employer that turns out to be using misleading, deceptive, or unethical businesses or hiring practices?
3. Facilitate a discussion about job fairs and the three models shared in the training. What is happening now? How is your agency involved?

Resources for Module 2, Lesson 4:

- » iGREET M2L4: Ethics of Business Recognition (Case Scenario)
Scenario for discussion: You have partnered with Smith's Garden Center for several years. They have successfully employed several people with disabilities and strive to create an inclusive workplace. Consider how you would go about honoring them at an upcoming Chamber of Commerce meeting.
- » iGREET M2L4: Iowa Reverse Job Fair Guide
This resource is a "how-to" guide in organizing a reverse job fair.

Videos for Module 2, Lesson 4:

- » Franklin Covey
- » Capacity Building
- » Abilities in Abundance



MODULE 3: STRATEGIC AND INDIVIDUALIZED EMPLOYER ENGAGEMENT

Module 3 applies the information provided in the previous iGREET lessons to strategic approaches to employer engagement. It brings foundational concepts, tools, and resources into the context of relationship building between state VR representatives and employers.

The learning objectives for Module 3 include:

1. Identify ways that labor market information supports understanding of the economic and sector landscape.
2. Identify employer engagement strategies relevant to a variety of different business types and cultures.
3. Understand the considerations and process for developing an Individualized Business Plan (IBP).
4. Determine strategies for adjusting employer engagement practices in response to environmental and economic challenges.

There are three lessons in Module 3:

Lesson 1: Understanding the Employer Landscape

Lesson 2: Every Business is Unique: Developing Individualized Business Plans

Lesson 3: Environmental, Economic, and other Challenging Situations in Employer Engagement

Module 3, Lesson 1: Understanding the Employer Landscape

Lesson summary for trainers:

The first lesson in Module 3 revisits labor market information (LMI) and business intelligence applied to the local job market. Trainees will identify growth sectors and the economic outlook for their state and local areas, applying a full range of employment data to target and plan employer engagement approaches.

Background knowledge and expertise

Trainers must be aware of:

- » the sources of LMI available nationally through the US Bureau of Labor Statistics, and state and agency-wide through public and private options
- » how to access and apply employment data and understand the benefits of using LMI and business intelligence
- » industry sectors and the importance of research into sector strategies for the local job market and preparation of job seekers
- » the differences among various business models and how a “one size fits all” approach may be counterproductive



Suggested discussion questions and activities:

1. Encourage a hands-on approach to exploring LMI. Demonstrate access to the resources available to participants and challenge them to share their research findings in group discussions.
2. Brainstorm strategies for connecting with sector and industry associations.
3. Review the *Employer Mapping* exercise as a group with these follow-up questions:
 - Were you already aware of the range of employers in your area? Share anything new that you learned.
 - Why is research important to employer engagement?
 - How can you share your research findings with partners? Why would you?
 - Do you have experience with sector strategies? If so, how was the knowledge helpful? Or not so helpful?
 - Provide one takeaway or detail from this exercise that you can apply to your employer engagement efforts.
1. Discussion question: When a job seeker isn't sure about what they want to do, but they are willing and able to work in many different vocations and the various occupations are all compatible with their strengths and disabilities, how could you use employer mapping to help narrow down where they may start with their job search and define their vocational goals?
2. Review the exercise on identifying the top five industry growth sectors.
 - What do you know about them? Were you already aware of them?
 - What are the businesses within identified sectors in your area?
 - What is the range of jobs in these businesses and sectors?

Resources for Module 3, Lesson 1:

- » iGREET M3L1: Ethical Dilemma: Ag-association Meeting (Case Scenario)
Scenario for discussion: You are invited to an agriculturally based trade association meeting by a colleague from the workforce center. You have heard that the association president is a manager at a local feed store who has a reputation for not fostering an inclusive workplace. You worry that your involvement would reflect badly on your agency and would not benefit the agency's clients. What should you do?
- » iGREET M3L1: Identifying Industry Sectors (Field Work Activity)
In this Field Work Activity, you will consider: What are the top five industry growth sectors in your area? What do you know about them? What are the businesses within identified sectors in your area? What is the range of jobs in these businesses and sectors?
- » iGREET M3L1: Employer Mapping Exercise
This mapping exercise is one source of agency business engagement LMI. This activity is designed to help users look for a wider range of potential businesses/organizations to approach as part of business engagement efforts.
- » iGREET M3L1: Explore VR Hidden Gems, Using Agency Business Relations LMI as Part of Your Labor Market Strategy
This article provides an overview of the need, sources, development, and use of agency business relations LMI, which is information gathered formally or informally from your sources on the ground and connected to the business community.



» iGREET M3L1: LMI for VR Counseling (Quick Guide)

This iGREET Quick Guide explains potential sources of LMI, how to identify trends within labor market data, and how understanding LMI may help VR counselors increase successful employment outcomes for people with disabilities.

» iGREET M3L1: LMI Overview (Quick Guide)

This iGREET Quick Guide offers an overview of LMI for VR services.

» iGREET M3L1: IBP Instructions and Content

This resource outlines the steps for creating an individualized business plan, including conducting a needs analysis, creating a proposal, and responding to changes and challenges.

Videos for Module 3, Lesson 1:

» Benefiting from a Sector Strategy Approach

Module 3, Lesson 2: Every Business is Unique: Developing Individualized Business Plans

Lesson summary for trainers:

Lesson 2 introduces the Individualized Business Plan (IBP), comparable to the Individualized Plan for Employment (IPE) for job seekers with disabilities. Using the sector research findings from Lesson 1 and gathering specific information by assessing the needs of a targeted employer, the IBP provides an agreement for delivering a range of services to a business. This lesson considers when it's appropriate to offer an IBP and how to introduce it to a business customer.

Workplace culture is an important consideration in developing a plan. This lesson explores the nuances of culture and the impact on employer engagement.

Background knowledge and expertise:

For this lesson, it is helpful for trainers to:

- » revisit the definitions of culture from Module 1 and become familiar with the differences in cultural competency and cultural humility
- » know your agency's policy (if any) on using IBPs, which is a relatively new concept for VR
- » become familiar with the IBP model and the position of the administration on its application

Suggested discussion questions and activities:

1. Engage trainees in discussions about what makes businesses unique. What are some of the ways staff can customize their approach with diverse types of businesses?
 - Are there industry sectors in your area that respond well to certain types of approaches?
2. Discuss the difference between cultural competency and cultural humility. Notice trainees' comfort level with these concepts.
 - Use fieldwork examples or create scenarios with employer engagement staff taking on different approaches. For example, what is your level of cultural competency in this example? How would you approach the scenario with cultural humility?
3. Review the fieldwork activity:
 - **Your experience:** Were there any considerations, strategies, or “ah-ha” moments that you identified from this exercise?



- **Application:** How will you use this information to inform your employer engagement strategies moving forward?
- 4. Brainstorm strategies for identifying the unique needs of employers.
- 5. Share and compare draft IBPs for North River Printing and review the trainees' experience with drafting the IBP.
- 6. Ask trainees to think about their current business customers. How would an IBP help? When might it be inappropriate? How would your agency/school track and share these plans once developed?

Resources for Module 3, Lesson 2:

- » iGREET M3L2: IBP Guide
This ICI resource explains the use of IBPs as well as a step-by-step explanation of how to develop an IBP.
- » iGREET M3L2: Example IBP: North River Printing
This resource provides an example of an IBP for North River Printing, a small business that provides design and printing services with positions in billing and accounting, customer service representatives, printer operators, graphic design, and customer account managers.
- » iGREET M3L2: Identifying Workplace Cultures (Fieldwork Activity)
This Fieldwork Activity asks you to consider diverse cultures in your business community and what steps you can take to factor that individuality into your employer engagement approach.

Videos for Module 3, Lesson 2:

- » Workplace Culture: IBPs



Module 3, Lesson 3: Environmental, Economic, and Other Challenging Situations in Employer Engagement

Lesson summary for trainers:

As implied in the title of Lesson 3, things do not always go as planned. This lesson addresses times when business is disrupted by unexpected crises and factors beyond our control. Employer relationships can be strengthened or weakened by our responses to challenges. This lesson explores possible constructive support for employers facing a variety of difficulties.

Background knowledge and expertise:

Trainers need to know about:

- » national, state, and local resources for emergency assistance
- » any agency policies regarding responding to emergencies (for staff and community-based purposes)
- » disaster preparedness for people with disabilities, including any state resources that support people with disabilities in planning for and coping with disasters
- » economic development grants or initiatives in the state

Suggested discussion questions and activities:

- » Review the ACME Manufacturing scenario and brainstorm strategies. Follow up with questions about the strategies' feasibility and effectiveness.
- » Have you encountered any emergency situations with employer customers? How did you handle it? How did it affect your plans with the business? How did it affect your relationship with the business?

Resources for Module 3, Lesson 3:

- » iGREET M3L3: Video Economic Downturn (Case Scenario)
Scenario for discussion: after watching this video, discuss what support VR could provide when a major employer experiences a mass layoff with a ripple effect in your area.
- » iGREET M3L3: Wildfire Destruction (Case Scenario)
Scenario for discussion: consider what to do when Spring Valley Accounting offices were burned in a wildfire and the employer calls you because someone you helped place there is not able to access the temporary offices in her wheelchair.

Web Resources:

- » [Emergency Preparedness for People with Disabilities \(US Dept. of Labor\)](#)
- » [Emergency Preparedness and Disabilities: Getting All Employees Out Safely \(SHRM\)](#)

Videos for Module 3, Lesson 3:

- » Acme Manufacturing Case Study



MODULE 4: EMPLOYMENT MODELS TO MEET EMPLOYER NEEDS

Module 4 expands the fundamentals of employer engagement to include a variety of employment strategies that support employer staffing needs as well as the principles of Competitive Integrated Employment (CIE). All the models included in Module 4 require a flexible mindset, creativity, and a focus on strengthening the ongoing relationship with an employer.

The learning objectives for Module 4 include:

1. Describe the relevance and components of Competitive Integrated Employment (CIE) as defined in the WIOA.
2. Understand the importance of developing trust when building relationships with employers and partner agencies.
3. Explore a variety of employment strategies and how they may be presented to employers.
4. Understand how the concept of job readiness relates to various employment models.
5. Demonstrate understanding of work-based learning (WBL), Progressive Employment, apprenticeships, and career pathways as potential employer engagement strategies.

There are four lessons in Module 3. They are:

Lesson 1: Meeting Employer Needs while Achieving Competitive Integrated Employment

Lesson 2: Supported Employment, Customized Employment, Flexible Employment Models, and Beyond

Lesson 3: Meeting Employer Needs: Work-Based Learning & Progressive Employment

Lesson 4: Meeting Employer Needs: Career Pathways and Apprenticeships

Module 4, Lesson 1: Meeting Employer Needs while Achieving Competitive Integrated Employment

Lesson summary for trainers:

The Rehabilitation Act requires that VR services be intended to result in Competitive Integrated Employment (CIE), and all the models covered in Module 4 support that goal. Lesson 1 emphasizes that compliance with the Rehab Act is the responsibility of VR, not the employer, and provides a review of CIE components as well as example checklists for evaluating whether a job opportunity is CIE. The lesson goes on to review the concept of job readiness and the intersection of job seeker talents, employer needs, and VR resources. There is also a reprise of the Zenger & Folkman research on the Three Elements of Trust covered in Module 2.

Background knowledge and expertise:

Trainers should be familiar with:

- » the definition of Competitive Integrated Employment in the WIOA and its four components
- » the agency's policies around CIE as well as any checklists or other tools the agency uses

Suggested discussion questions and activities:

- » Review the thrift store example in the lesson and discuss this question: "Based on what you



know, would you consider this CIE? Why or why not?”

- » Share one or both CIE checklist examples.
 - If your agency has a similar tool, how does it compare?
 - If not, do people think such a tool might be useful?
- » Discussion question for non-VR agencies: are your services all aimed at helping people achieve CIE, or do you support other goals as well? Who decides what those goals are?
- » The lesson states that job readiness is a product of a good fit between the employer and job seeker, not on any other kind of generic measurement or assumptions. What do you think?

Resources for Module 4, Lesson 1:

- » iGREET M4L1: Module 4 Key Terms (Quick Guide)
This iGREET Quick Guide explains key terms from Module 4.
- » iGREET M4L1: CIE Handouts
This handout reviews the Colorado Department of Labor and Employment and the Michigan Department of Health and Human Services, Michigan Rehabilitation Services Evaluations for Competitive Integrated Employment (CIE). These forms are used to determine whether a job seeker’s particular employment situation meets the criteria for competitive integrated employment, on a case-by-case basis, alongside VR counselors.
- » iGREET M4L1_Elements of Trust (Zenger and Folkman HBR) (originally described in M2L3)
This research found three behaviors that form the foundation of trust: Positive Relationships, Good Judgment, and Consistency. Leaders don’t have to be perfect in all three to be successful—they simply need to be above average.

Module 4, Lesson 2: Supported Employment, Customized Employment, Flexible Employment Models, and Beyond

Lesson summary for trainers:

Lesson 2 starts with a review of the essentials of Supported Employment (SE), framing it to meet the needs of the employer through the provision of pre-screening, job support, and accommodations while connecting employers with an untapped talent pool. Lesson 2 also reviews Customized Employment (CE) which addresses a business’s unmet needs and provides opportunities for job seekers that may not fit into or be interested in existing job positions. Finally, Lesson 2 reviews flexible employment models, such as contract work, temporary-to-hire, temporary employment, on-call work, and remote work, examining the employer engagement implications of each approach as well as the career counseling considerations.

Background knowledge and expertise:

The trainer should be knowledgeable about:

- » how the agency provides Supported Employment services
- » whether the agency offers Customized Employment services, and if so, what training is available for staff to understand CE as an employer service
- » any agency policies regarding flexible employment models— for example, when/whether your agency would help an SE participant access temporary employment given that they would need intensive training and support each time they received a new assignment



Suggested discussion questions and activities:

As with all the lessons, it is helpful to facilitate a group discussion about the content and invite questions. Here are some specific suggestions:

1. What are some concerns employers have in hiring people who need SE? What are some ways you have helped address those concerns?
2. Which employment options does your agency offer (e.g., does your agency provide CE services?) and how might they be presented to employers?
3. If anyone in the group has experience in CE, invite them to share examples of the process and outcomes. However, be prepared to explain that just because a job is altered to better fit a new employee, that does not make it customized employment. CE has a prescribed set of components and a very structured approach.
4. How have staff explained employment strategies such as SE or CE to employers, using business-friendly language?
 - Think about the Russ and Neil video—what did Russ do well in his approach? What should he do to improve his approach?

Resources for Module 4, Lesson 2:

- » iGREET M4L2: CE & Craft Store (Case Scenario)
Scenario for discussion: You are thinking about a customized position as a solution to help keep a business sales floor organized. How would you propose this business solution and answer the employer's questions and concerns?
- » iGREET M4L2: Perspectives of Employers on Customized Employment (LEAD Center Brief)
This information brief provides the results of six focus groups conducted in 2015 under ODEP's Employment First State Leadership Mentoring Program (EFSLMP). The focus groups' purpose was to garner the perspective of employers of diverse sizes, sectors, and locations who hired people with disabilities into customized jobs within the past year.
- » iGREET M4L2: The Essential Elements of Customized Employment for Universal Application
This document was developed through a network of partners to identify the essential elements of CE as a guide for the universal application of these elements across service delivery and training providers.

Web Resources:

- » [ODEP Program Areas: Customized Employment](#)
- » [Marc Gold: What is Customized Employment?](#)
- » [Ask JAN Customized Employment](#)

Module 4, Lesson 3: Meeting Employer Needs through Work-Based Learning & Progressive Employment

Lesson summary for trainers:

Lesson 3 reviews two specific approaches to serving both job seekers and employers: work-based learning and Progressive Employment. For job seekers, work-based learning (WBL) is often used as a tool to provide real-life work experience to help develop employability, knowledge, and skills. However, its benefits are often overlooked as a tool to meet employer needs as well.

The lesson covers seven key principles for developing and implementing WBL as well as three



categories of WBL activities: 1) exploration (company tours, informational interviews, job shadows), 2) preparation (internships, work experiences, pre-apprenticeships), and 3) training (on-the-job training, apprenticeships).

This lesson also covers Progressive Employment (PE), which incorporates the business concept of a “risk-free trial” for job seekers and employers as well as a team approach to WBL. The lesson covers the four components of the PE model and how a team approach can lead to employer connections.

Background knowledge and expertise:

The trainer should be knowledgeable about:

- » the agency’s use of (or partnership in) WBL activities and the advantages for job seekers and employers:
 - Who participates?
 - How are WBL activities developed and supported?
 - If CRPs are involved, how are the services coordinated with VR staff?
 - What kind of activities are most often used?
- » the use of On-the-Job Training (OJT) in your agency, and if OJTs are not being used, what information do staff need to know to provide it as an employment resource?
- » the use of PE, and the agency is using the PE model, be prepared to review the model components and how they are implemented in your state
 - For example, how often does the team meet and how is data collected?
 - If your agency does not use PE, are there opportunities to talk with leadership about pursuing it as an option?

Suggested discussion questions and activities:

1. Review the list of possible WBL activities. Discuss which activities your agency currently uses most, and which seem to be the most useful.
 - If there are WBL activities that are not being used, why is that?
 - Are there any WBL activities that are unfamiliar to your team? Use the discussion as an opportunity to consider innovative approaches.
2. Coordinate a discussion about OJT and how it is used in your agency. Are people familiar with the approach? Could they describe it to an employer?
3. Similarly, review the *Scale-up Progressive Employment* handout with the group and discuss:
 - Which of the components are already in place within your agency?
 - Which components could be developed to support your employer engagement efforts?
4. For non-VR trainers/trainees: how is your state VR agency involved in WBL? What is your role in the partnership? Do you feel that WBL activities are contributing to successful hiring for employers? How could they be better used?
5. Consider including the following exercise about a job seeker named Hector:
 - Hector, age 18, has no work experience and no clue of what he wants to do for work.
 - He is good with his hands and works hard at home and school. He is on the autism spectrum; he is verbal but not chatty. He is very passive about career choices. He has been pampered and protected from life experience by his family.
 - You want to arrange a tour and informational interview with a business (of your choosing) for Hector so that he can have some worksite exposure.



Discussion Questions:

- » Identify an employer you would contact for Hector.
- » Think about what you will say when you contact the business you have identified.
- » Write a short script of your elevator pitch, but then expand it to talk about Hector (an elevator pitch plus an ask about Hector)

Resources for Module 4, Lesson 3:

Work-based Learning:

- » iGREET M4L3_ OJT Agreement example—Blank Copy Calif
This sample letter of agreement about on-the-job training is an example of how the California Department of Rehabilitation and an employer agree to enter an OJT Agreement to provide OJT to a trainee.
- » iGREET_M4, L3_PE and the Warehouse (Case Scenario)
Scenario for discussion: This scenario demonstrates how a team approach can lead you to employer connections, and how Progressive Employment can open doors for employment opportunities.
- » iGREET M4L3_ Sample Flyer on OJT from WA State
This sample flyer from WA State describes what OJT is, how it works, and how it benefits business.

Progressive Employment:

- » iGREET M4L3: PE and the Warehouse (Case Scenario)
This fact sheet provides resources and ways that your agency can benefit from Progressive Employment (PE), and reviews PE, which provides an integrated approach to addressing the needs of the dual customer: job seekers with disabilities and businesses.
- » iGREET M4L3: ICI Scale up PE Fact Sheet.
This resource covers the four component parts of the Scale-Up PE model and describes how VR agencies can work with ICI to develop a customized PE implementation plan based on a self-assessment and operational needs.
- » iGREET M4L3: PE as Dual-customer Model (article: Journal of Vocational Rehabilitation)
This paper describes the evolution of Progressive Employment (PE) in Vermont and aims to define the key features and critical components of PE as a distinct model of dual-customer service delivery. Findings suggest that the PE approach has promise as an effective dual-customer model, especially for job seekers with little or no successful work experience. It discusses salient elements of the model and replication considerations.
- » iGREET M4L3: Progressive Employment: What We Offer (ICI resource)
This ICI resource describes the PE model, the employment outcomes, resources, and how to learn more.

Web Resources:

- » Pre-Employment Transition Services(Pre-ETS): [WINTAC's resources on Pre-ETS and WBL](#)
- » [ExploreVR Progressive Employment Research](#)

Videos for Module 4, Lesson 3:

- » The Benefits of WBL
- » Progressive Employment in VT



Module 4, Lesson 4: Meeting Employer Needs through Career Pathways and Apprenticeships

Lesson summary for trainers:

This final lesson looks at two employment models: Career Pathways and Apprenticeships.

- » Career Pathways involve clear and specific strategies to raise job seekers' skill levels for career development and advancement.
- » Apprenticeships are industry-driven, high-quality career pathways where employers can develop and prepare their future workforce. Individuals can obtain paid work experience, classroom instruction, and nationally recognized portable credentials.

Using these models can help build a pipeline of skilled candidates to fill in-demand positions and can give people with disabilities, who are often left behind, the opportunity to advance their careers.

Background knowledge and expertise:

The trainer should be knowledgeable about:

- » the benefits of the Career Pathways approach to meeting employer hiring and retention needs, and how your agency is involved (if it is)
- » if your state has a statewide Career Pathway Initiative in place, and some familiarity with the plan and the players
- » apprenticeship resources in your agency and state, and if your agency has an assigned apprenticeship coordinator, consider inviting that person to join the discussion with your team to be sure everyone understands what is available
- » who your apprenticeship partners are, what work is already being done in your state, and what your agency's goals are
- » how your agency is involved in interagency grants or initiatives that support apprenticeships or related workforce development strategies

Suggested discussion questions and activities:

1. Review the core principles of Career Pathways and discuss how these are implemented in your agency (or for trainees from partner agencies, how they are implemented in your partnership with VR).
 - If they are not implemented yet, where could they be useful? What are the barriers preventing use of these approaches?
 - You might want to [share this ExploreVR video about Career Pathways](#) as part of the discussion.
2. Review the field work assignment exploring Maker Spaces in your area and follow up on the assignment:
 - "Identify at least one maker space type resource that you found in your area and identify the next step you want to take in developing a partnership. If you are already working with a maker space, please describe the partnership."
3. Review the *Apprenticeship Partners* graphic in the lesson and as a group, identify local/state examples in each of the categories.
 - Discuss what your agency is doing (or could be doing) to incorporate diversity, equity, inclusion, and accessibility practices in any of the models presented in this module (including WBL, SE, CE, PE, career pathways, apprenticeships, etc.) and use the question to spark a brainstorming discussion with your team.



- » Share the following scenarios with the group, and discuss these questions:
 - How will this influence and/or change your outreach and communication with employers in the identified sectors?
 - How do you start thinking about inclusion with this model? What might be some barriers to inclusion?
 - What are implementation challenges/barriers?

Scenario 1: You found out about a manufacturing apprenticeship program based in a metropolitan area in your state. Manufacturing is an occupation with above average potential for that metro area, and due to inability to fill positions, employers have increased starting wages 20% in the last 6 months. Several of the job seeker customers you serve have reported interest in this type of work and are good candidates but live in the most rural areas of the state. Some have indicated a willingness to relocate if they were to be accepted into the apprenticeship program, but most would not be able to despite their interest.

Your director has given you permission to create a workgroup to collaborate with the apprenticeship program with a goal of getting your agency (VR, School to Work, CRP, AJC) at the table and being able to refer job seekers to the program.

Scenario 2: The Workforce System in your state is leading a statewide Career Pathways effort focused on four sectors: 1) information technology, 2) finance, 3) healthcare, and 4) Science, Technology, Engineering, and Math (STEM). While some of the occupations in these sectors may require onsite training and work, there is considerable potential for participating and working remotely. Your agency's leadership has been involved in some preliminary discussions and has been invited to have representation in the workgroup. Your director has asked you to be the representative with the goal of providing 15 opportunities for customers to participate by the end of the first year, and 40 in the second year and beyond.

Resources for Module 4, Lesson 4:

Career Pathways Resources:

- » iGREET M4L4: Identifying Maker Spaces (Fieldwork)
In this field work activity, you explore what types of maker spaces are in your area, including spaces within schools, adult education programs, or community programs that may have workshops and spaces that are open to the public.
- » iGREET M4L4: Legislation related to Career Pathways (Quick Guide)
This Quick Guide reviews seven pieces of legislation related to apprenticeship and career pathways, including the ADA, IDEA, Section 504 of the 1973 Rehabilitation Act, WIOA, Perkins V, CARES, and the EEO.
- » iGREET M4L4: Career Tech: Career Clusters Pathways
This resource lists several examples of various career options that fall into 16 different career categories or clusters ranging from agriculture to transportation and everything in between.

Apprenticeship Resources:

- » iGREET M4L4: Apprenticeship as an Employer Engagement Option (Case Scenario)
Scenario for discussion: Consider what your first steps would be to connect with an employer about a manufacturing apprenticeship program in a rural area when the employer has some concerns about their capacity to train and the registration process.



» iGREET M4L4: DOL Apprenticeship Fact Sheet

This fact sheet describes what an apprenticeship is, provides examples of apprenticeships offered in multiple industries, reviews the benefits of apprenticeship to businesses and job seekers, covers the steps to getting the process started, and includes resources to learn more.

» iGREET M4L4: DOL_ Advancing RA for PwD

This fact sheet describes apprenticeships to advance opportunities, reviews the role of the DOL Offices of Apprenticeship, describes the Apprenticeship Inclusion Models Demonstration Project, discusses equal employment opportunity within apprenticeship, and includes resources to learn more.

» iGREET M4L4: ExploreVR Pre-Apprenticeship Fact Sheet

This Explore VR fact sheet covers what pre-apprenticeship is, the difference between pre-apprenticeship and registered apprenticeship, what organizations commonly lead pre-apprenticeship programs, who are potential key partners, steps to identify partners, funding sources, and a framework with the key components of pre-apprenticeship programs.

» iGREET M4L4: ExploreVR Step-by-Step Apprenticeship Guide

This step-by-step guide to implementing apprenticeship programs helps you to consider how to access, identify, build, evaluate, strategize, implement, and improve apprenticeships in developing paid work experience programs.

» iGREET M4L4: Workforce System & RA Alignment Resource

This resource from the American Institutes for Research offers background on the registered apprenticeship and workforce systems, dimensions of apprenticeship and workforce systems alignment, strategies to strengthen alignment, resources, and a system alignment checklist.

Web Resources:

Examples of Active Maker Spaces:

- » [Wyoming Innovation Wyrkshop](#)
- » [Makerspace NYC](#)

National Apprenticeship Information:

- » [Apprenticeship.gov](#)
- » Explore [approved occupations for US registered apprenticeship](#)

Apprenticeship Technical Assistance, Resources and Best Practices:

- » [Jobs for the Future \(JFF\)'s National Innovation Hub for Diversity, Equity, Inclusion, and Accessibility in Registered Apprenticeships](#)
- » [Partnership on Inclusive Apprenticeships \(PIA\)](#)
- » [Equity in Apprenticeship: Four case studies and summaries](#)

Videos for Module 4, Lesson 4:

- » Why Apprenticeship?
- » Registered Apprenticeship and VR's Role
- » Integrating Maine VR with Apprenticeship
- » Apprenticeship and Employer Engagement



NEXT STEPS AFTER COMPLETING THE IGREET MODULES

As the training ends for your team, discuss these questions:

1. What did you get from these modules?
2. What are your next steps internally in the agency? (Things to do or explore? People to connect with?)
3. What are your next steps with external partners? (agencies to connect with?)
4. What have you learned that you want to try to use in your employer engagement efforts?
5. What do you need to improve upon in your employer engagement skills?
6. How can you and your agency establish a system of ongoing professional development in employer engagement?
7. How can you support creating a Community of Practice on employer engagement within your agency, community, or state?
8. How will you engage employers who represent diverse cultures/backgrounds/perspectives from you? What if you do not like the person?
9. Has this training led you to identify other areas of training needs?

The Program on Innovative Rehabilitation Training on Employer Engagement is a project of ExploreVR at the Institute for Community Inclusion, UMass Boston. ExploreVR offers VR agencies easy and convenient access to a range of VR research, related data, training and tools for planning, evaluation, and decision-making. Funding for this project is provided by the Rehabilitation Services Administration (RSA) Grant #H263C190012.

